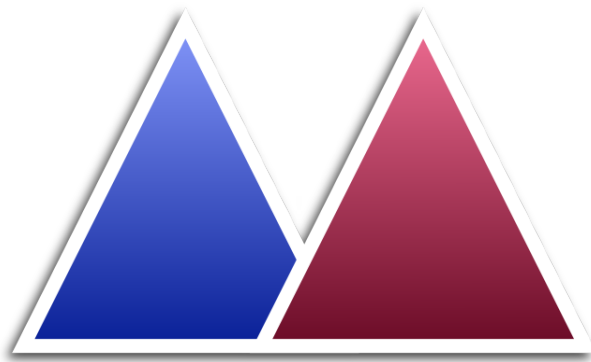




M A J U

***Better Bridges, Wider Webs: Fostering Youth
Entrepreneurship in Singapore***

Providing opportunities to strengthen the entrepreneurial spirit in our local youths

By: 02/Economics and Finance Policy Centre, MAJU

Authors: Li Laiyi • Jordan Lim • Valene Lim • Esther Ong • Yeo Tok Lin • [REDACTED]

ABOUT MAJU

This policy paper summary was written by members of MAJU. MAJU is an independent, youth-led organisation that focuses on engaging Singaporean youths in a long-term research process to guide them in jointly formulating policy ideas of their own.

By sharing our unique youth perspectives, MAJU hopes to contribute to the policymaking discourse and future of Singapore.

CONTENT PAGE

1. INTRODUCTION	6
1.1 Reasons for Limited Youth Entrepreneurship	7
1.1.1 Monetary Considerations	7
1.1.2 Societal Norms Encouraging Structured Employment	7
1.1.3 Stigma of Failure	7
1.2 Benefits of Supporting Youth Entrepreneurship	8
1.2.1 Building an Innovative Economy	8
1.2.2 Catalysing Economic Development	8
1.2.3 Nurturing Skills for Youths	9
2. PROBLEM STATEMENT	10
2.1 Consequences Of A Lack Of Entrepreneurship	10
2.2 Existing Initiatives to Support Entrepreneurship in Singapore	10
2.2.1 National Youth Council/ Campfire	10
2.2.2 Venture for Good	11
2.2.3 Startup SG Tech	11
2.2.4 Startup SG Founder	12
2.2.5 ACE and EDGE	12
2.2.6 Post-secondary Education Institutions (Polytechnics)	13
2.2.7 Institutes of Higher Learning (IHLs)	14
2.2.8 Non-Profit Organisations Collaborating with Secondary Schools	15
2.3 Summary: Distilling the Fundamental Issue	16
3. ANALYSIS OF SURVEY FINDINGS	17
3.1 Overview of Respondents	17
3.1.1 On Running a Business	17
3.1.2 On Wanting to Start a Business	17
3.1.3 On Not Wanting to Start a Business	18
3.2 General Takeaways	18
3.2.1 Key takeaway 1: Youths have low awareness of existing entrepreneurship programmes	18
3.2.2. Key takeaway 2: Youths think it would be useful to spark interest in entrepreneurship from young	19
3.3 Key takeaways from Respondents Interested in Entrepreneurship/Own a Business (Group A)	19
3.3.1. Key takeaway 1: Group A has low awareness of the various government schemes available to entrepreneurs	20
3.3.2. Key takeaway 2: Group A believe building a community passionate about entrepreneurship is important	21

3.4 Key takeaways from Respondents Uninterested in Entrepreneurship (Group B)	22
3.4.1. Key takeaway 1: Group B's disinterest mainly stems from insufficient knowledge	22
3.4.2. Key takeaway 2: Group B's disinterest in entrepreneurship could be changed with greater access to knowledge and expertise	23
4. PROPOSED INITIATIVES	24
4.1 Zonal Entrepreneurship Offices (ZEOs)	24
4.1.1 Overview of ZEOs	24
4.1.2 Flaws and Possible Mitigation	25
4.1.3 Avenues for Expansion	26
4.2 The Nationwide Entrepreneur Network (NEN)	26
4.2.1 Overview of the NEN	26
4.2.2 Flaws and Possible Mitigation	28
4.2.3 Avenues for Expansion	28
5. CONCLUSION	29
APPENDIX	30
BIBLIOGRAPHY	46

1. INTRODUCTION

The government recognises the importance of entrepreneurship in stimulating its economic development and has played a significant role in creating a vibrant entrepreneurial-ecosystem by supporting a multitude of programmes touched on below. It has focused on increasing youth entrepreneurship as well, with the Campfire Programme launched by the National Youth Council to teach youth about entrepreneurship and social enterprise.

Singapore supports entrepreneurial efforts as it believes it is integral to Singapore's economic development in improving productivity, fostering innovation, and increasing employment. This outlook towards entrepreneurship was recently emphasised by Deputy Prime Minister Heng Swee Keat at the Singapore APEX Business Summit, where he spoke on the importance of entrepreneurship and innovation in the current economic climate.¹ In particular, DPM Heng emphasised how human capital and innovation are critical in driving the economy in a resource-scarce country like Singapore. Furthermore, entrepreneurship often integrates a social aspect to its operations, with many seeking to address societal issues that might be undersupported by the public sector. For these reasons, the government has been giving greater attention to entrepreneurship.² This also makes it desirable for Singapore to aim to secure its position as the "Silicon Valley of Asia".³

However, Singapore has close competition. Currently, Singapore is ranked 7th in the world by the Global Innovation Index, with regional competitors such as the Republic of Korea ranking at 6th, and close competitors China and Japan ranking 11th and 13th respectively.⁴ Singapore needs to increase its focus on innovation to stay ahead of the curve. Furthermore, a relatively low rate of youth entrepreneurship persists in Singapore with only 17% of youths in 2019 aspiring to be entrepreneurs, last among 6 countries in Southeast Asia.⁵ Our youths are our entrepreneurs of tomorrow - if fewer are interested in pursuing this path, the title "Silicon Valley of Asia" will be harder to attain.

Therefore, this youth position paper hopes to shed light on the youth perspective on entrepreneurship. After laying out potential reasons for limited youth entrepreneurship and the

¹ Swee Keat Heng, "DPM Heng Swee Keat at the Singapore Apex Business Summit," Prime Minister's Office Singapore, March 22, 2022,

<https://www.pmo.gov.sg/Newsroom/DPM-Heng-Swee-Keat-at-the-Singapore-APEX-Business-Summit>.

² Oon Tian Sern, "Commentary: The Future Just Got Brighter for Aspiring Singapore Tech Entrepreneurs," CNA, February 17, 2020,

<https://www.channelnewsasia.com/commentary/singapore-tech-entrepreneurs-start-up-grants-youth-challenge-774631>.

³ Economic Development Board, "What it took to build Singapore's own Silicon Valley," EDB, December 22, 2022, <https://www.edb.gov.sg/en/business-insights/insights/what-it-took-to-build-singapores-own-silicon-valley.html>

⁴ WIPO, "Global Innovation Index 2022 – Which Are the Most Innovative Countries," RSS News, 2022, https://www.wipo.int/global_innovation_index/en/2022/.

⁵ Kimberly Lim, "Few Singaporean Youths Aim to Be Entrepreneurs, Most Have No Plans to Work Overseas: WEF Survey," TODAY, August 17, 2019,

<https://www.todayonline.com/singapore/singapore-youths-come-last-survey-six-nations-entrepreneurial-ambition>.

benefits of increasing it, we present results we obtained from our survey on youth entrepreneurship. Based on the results, we suggest possible policies that could help encourage more youths to consider this pathway.

1.1 Reasons for Limited Youth Entrepreneurship

We recognise that encouraging youths to pursue entrepreneurial initiatives can be potentially difficult due to the following considerations.

1.1.1 Monetary Considerations and Lack of Expertise

Monetary considerations may discourage youths from pursuing entrepreneurial initiatives as they lack sufficient start-up funding due to potentially high manpower and operating costs.⁶ While it is important to be prudent with funding such that initiatives are profitable, the bar for assessing such funding might be too high for youth entrepreneurs who do not have as much expertise, connections, and resources. Therefore, youths interested in pursuing such ventures require training to understand how to manage their manpower and operating costs, as well as better access to more funding.

Although the government does provide significant grants of up to 70% of initial round funding for some startups, this might still be insufficient.⁷ Seed funding itself is very high, typically around US\$500,000 to \$1,000,000, which requires aspiring entrepreneurs to secure investors through well-developed business proposals, where, again, they might not have the necessary resources or skill sets for.⁸ Thus, funding and expertise presents itself as a two-pronged issue.

1.1.2 Societal Norms Encouraging Structured Employment

Furthermore, pursuing entrepreneurial efforts takes time and rewards are not guaranteed, a risk youths might be unwilling to take. Coupled with societal norms that push aspiring youth entrepreneurship to settle for ‘safer’ choices like structured employment, youths may be less inclined to pursue entrepreneurial efforts as opposed to spending their limited time and energy on more ‘typical’ activities, or activities where the benefits are more immediately enjoyed.⁹

⁶ William Kerr and Ramana Nada, “Financing Constraints and Entrepreneurship,” National Bureau of Economic Research, November, 2009, https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w15498/w15498.pdf.

⁷ Startup SG, “Startup SG - the Singapore Startup Ecosystem”, 2022, <https://www.startupsg.gov.sg/programmes>.

⁸ Ryan Rutan, “Series A, B, C, D, and E Funding: How It Works,” Series A, B, C, D, and E Funding: How It Works | Startups.com, April 26, 2022, <https://www.startups.com/library/expert-advice/series-funding-a-b-c-d-e>.

⁹ Abigail Ng, “Singapore’s entrepreneurs have often had to overcome family pressure — but that may be slowly changing,” CNBC, September 25, 2020, <https://www.cnbc.com/2020/09/25/family-pressure-on-singapore-entrepreneurs-eases-.html>

1.1.3 Stigma of Failure

Aspiring youth entrepreneurs may struggle with balancing their academic workload with other commitments in both their school and personal lives. Consequently, uncertain success, paired with the fear of being perceived negatively by others should their ventures fail, could discourage youths from pursuing entrepreneurial ideas. There is also a strong sense of shame perpetuated in Singaporean society, when entrepreneurial ventures fail.¹⁰ This discourages aspiring entrepreneurs from attempting another business idea, even though multiple attempts might be needed for success to eventually be delivered.

1.2 Benefits of Supporting Youth Entrepreneurship

Supporting youth entrepreneurship brings about a host of important benefits, ranging from individual to nationwide impacts.

1.2.1 Building an Innovative Economy

Singapore ranks as the No. 2 most innovative nation in East Asia, Southeast Asia and Oceania on the Global Innovation Index 2022.¹¹ However, innovation in Singapore is dominated by either multinational corporations (MNCs), or local firms with links to state-owned enterprises (SOEs) or government linked companies (GLCs).¹² To supplement these pillars of innovation, the Research, Innovation, and Enterprise 2025 Plan by the National Research Foundation calls for a vibrant local startup ecosystem to be developed, with a key prong being the nurturing of entrepreneurial skills among youths to grow a strong pool of Innovation and Enterprise (I&E) talent.¹³ The growth of such talent will undoubtedly accelerate the founding of successful entrepreneurial ventures, such as Sea Limited and Love, Bonito. In turn, Singapore can further drive its transition into an innovative economy that is competitive abroad and provides new job opportunities for citizens.

1.2.2 Catalysing Economic Development

Successful entrepreneurship ventures also bring with them opportunities for economic development, such as catalysed economic transition and increased job opportunities. Over 20,000

¹⁰ Christopher Quek, “The Shame Faced by Singapore Startup Founders Who Fail Is Real. Here's What We Can Do,” TODAY, September 18, 2019, <https://www.todayonline.com/commentary/shame-faced-singapore-startup-founders-who-fail-real-heres-what-we-can-do>.

¹¹ “Global Innovation Index 2022 – Which Are the Most Innovative Countries?”

¹² Jue Wang, “Innovation and Government Intervention: A Comparison of Singapore and Hong Kong,” *Research Policy* 47, no. 2 (2018): pp. 399-412, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.respol.2017.12.008>.

¹³ National Research Foundation, “Rie2025 Plan,” National Research Foundation, 2021, <https://www.nrf.gov.sg/rie2025-plan>.

people are employed by Singaporean startups, and these businesses punch far above their weight economically, with tech startups in particular contributing 2.40% to Singapore's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) despite only employing 0.57% of the working population. Youths are likely to play an increasingly important role in promoting economic development, as the growth of startups is increasingly driven by youth entrepreneurs. For instance, 40% of social enterprises are led by leadership teams where the majority of members are under 35 years old, while only 10% have leadership teams whose majority are aged 55 years old or more.¹⁴

Furthermore, both established and nascent Singaporean brands continue to provide job opportunities to locals, increasing employment rates. For example, Sea Limited has offered to train an additional 500 Singaporeans in a programme with the Infocomm Media Development Authority (IMDA), on top of the 3000 employees they already have based in Singapore.¹⁵

1.2.3 Nurturing Skills for Youths

Entrepreneurship is a means for youths to nurture business, technical, and life skills. First, by venturing into entrepreneurship, youths allow themselves to learn beyond their chosen field(s) of study, providing an interdisciplinary environment for their professional and personal development. Second, by dealing with a challenging work environment, youth are presented with an opportunity to navigate the intricacies of setting up and running a business. Youths could pick up invaluable lessons, be it in the form of business skills such as marketing, sales and financial management, or life skills such as critical thinking, resilience, and effective communication. Third, in the course of starting a business, youths are forced to engage with a multitude of stakeholders. In the process, not only will youths get to forge networks and friendships, it will also allow them to build their repository of social know-hows and communication skills.

¹⁴ Singapore Centre for Social Enterprise, raiSE Ltd. "The State of Social Enterprise in Singapore," raiSE, February 25, 2021, https://www.britishcouncil.org/sites/default/files/the_state_of_social_enterprise_in_singapore_0.pdf?_ga=2.123354248.249985035.1680268718-1461087208.1680268718&_gl=1*un92u*_ga*MTQ2MTA4NzIwOC4xNjgwMjY4NzE4*_ga_X5M3D7HLQQ*MTY4MDI2ODcxOC4xLjAuMTY4MDI2ODcxOC42MC4wLjA.

¹⁵ Rachel Phua, "Shopee's Parent Company Sea Commits to Hiring 500 Singaporeans in Tie-up with Imda," CNA, October 2, 2020, <https://www.channelnewsasia.com/singapore/shopee-sea-imda-commits-to-hiring-500-singaporeans-730291>.

2. PROBLEM STATEMENT

2.1 Consequences Of A Lack Of Entrepreneurship

As Singapore strives to maintain its economic dynamism in an increasingly competitive and unpredictable global economy, the consequences of falling rates of entrepreneurship can be detrimental to our economic goals.

With no natural resources, Singapore relies heavily on innovation inputs and high-value added activities to fuel its economy. A lack of entrepreneurship may result in reduced introduction of innovative technologies and services.¹⁶ In addition, it may also lead to reduced challenges to existing firms, which in turn discourages them from innovating and investing in research and development (R&D) for greater economic efficiency.¹⁷ On a broader scale, there might also be lower job creation in the long term,¹⁸ if home-grown enterprises are not sufficiently established.

Hence, it is crucial to foster entrepreneurship and innovation, particularly among youths, if Singapore seeks to maintain its comparative advantage in the future global economy.

2.2 Existing Initiatives to Support Entrepreneurship in Singapore

We surveyed existing initiatives to support entrepreneurship in Singapore. Some of which were government-linked organisations and government-backed grants that sought to promote innovation, often at the start-up level. Others mainly involve educational institutions that hope to develop entrepreneurship amongst youths in Singapore, and provide them with resources to learn the basics of entrepreneurship. Overall, while these initiatives were broadly helpful to aspiring entrepreneurs, they could be seen as rather limited in the scope and extent of support. The following table summarises the benefits and limitations of existing policy options, with the detailed descriptions of the policy options in the appendix.

¹⁶ Alexander S. Kritikos, “Entrepreneurs and Their Impact on Jobs and Economic Growth,” IZA World of Labor, May 1, 2014, <https://wol.iza.org/articles/entrepreneurs-and-their-impact-on-jobs-and-economic-growth/long>.

¹⁷ Bloom, N., Van Reenen, J., & Williams, H. (2019). A toolkit of policies to promote innovation. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 33(3), 163-184.

¹⁸ Audretsch, D. B., Cunningham, J. A., & Kuratko, D. F. (2018). The missing link: The knowledge filter and entrepreneurship in endogenous growth. *Small Business Economics*, 51(2), 399-411.

Table 2.1: Summary of benefits and limitations of existing policy options

Existing Policy	Benefits	Limitations
NYC/Campfire	Established programmes that can provide comprehensive training to youths	Projects often require a social aspect, which limits the scope of eligible ideas.
Venture for Good	Provides substantial grants to social enterprises, supported by a multitude of relevant agencies.	Targets existing social enterprises, hence does not really support nascent projects.
Startup SG Tech	Provides substantial grants to startups that have demonstrated proof-of-concept or proof-of-value	Stringent requirement means that eligible projects must have already carried out substantive research and proof of commercial viability.
Startup SG Founder	Provides different tracks for aspiring entrepreneurs who may be at different points of their entrepreneurship journey.	Requires full-time commitment to be eligible for its grants.
ACE - EDGE	Connects aspiring entrepreneurs to the greater startup ecosystem, as well as relevant partners.	Does not provide funding, only networking and educational resources.
Post-secondary Education Institutions	Provides learning opportunities to youths within and outside the school.	More limited in resources than the support provided by IHLs, when it comes to starting businesses.
Institutes of Higher Learning	Multifaceted support programmes that tackle training, funding and networking.	Limited to students/staff of respective IHLs.
NPO programmes in Secondary schools	Able to encourage innovation and critical thinking at a young age.	Only benefit a small group of schools, often subject to decisions of school management. Lack of consistency of programme material provided by different organisations.

2.3 Summary: Distilling the Fundamental Issue

While the Singaporean government recognises the importance of entrepreneurship in stimulating Singapore's economic development and job creation, and has continuously invested resources to create a vibrant entrepreneurial-ecosystem, existing initiatives may be insufficient in reference to Table 2.1. There is hence room for our proposal paper to address these limitations in our proposed solutions, which will be elaborated under Section 4.

3. ANALYSIS OF SURVEY FINDINGS

We conducted a survey in November 2022 amongst Singaporean youths to better understand their thoughts on the entrepreneurship scene in Singapore and their own interest in entrepreneurship. The survey received responses from 79 respondents ranging across the ages of 18-27, with the largest representation coming from those aged 21 years old (54% of our respondents). 8.9% of respondents were already currently running a business, 21.5% of respondents were intending to start a business, and 69.6% of respondents were not intending to start a business.

Through these results, we were able to identify two key demographics that require greater support: Group A, youths who are interested in setting up/have already set up their own businesses, but lack knowledge and support and Group B, youths who lack interest in and/or knowledge of entrepreneurship (the majority of respondents).

3.1 Overview of Respondents

3.1.1 On Running a Business

Out of the seven respondents currently running a business, the more common types of businesses run were “Importing and selling products” and “Selling your service/expertise (tutoring, marketing, freelance writing, housecleaning, etc)”, with both categories represented by two respondents each. Yet, out of these seven respondents, three respondents did not have their business formally registered in Singapore, and two out of these three respondents did not intend to formally register their business.

When questioned about their reasons for wanting to formally register their business, the only respondent who replied as such identified “I believe in the growth potential of my business” and “I want to grow my business further” as reasons they identified with.

3.1.2 On Wanting to Start a Business

Out of the 17 respondents wanting to start a business, the more common types of businesses that respondents wanted to create were businesses related to “Importing and selling products” and “Selling your service/expertise (tutoring, marketing, freelance writing, housecleaning, etc)”, with both categories represented by ten respondents each. However, when questioned about their reasons for wanting to start a business, the most common reason cited was about the possibility of making profits. Notably, our survey results revealed that a person’s reasons for wanting to be an entrepreneur might simply be to fulfil their dreams, such as a respondent who wanted to start a pub simply because that was his dream that he hoped to fulfil.

However, the **most common reasons** that our respondents perceived to discourage them from starting a business were “Insufficient knowledge and expertise” and “Lack of capital/funds”.

3.1.3 On Not Wanting to Start a Business

Out of our 79 survey respondents, **55 respondents did not intend to start a business**, with the most **common reason being “Insufficient knowledge and expertise” and “Insufficient interest”**. While 29% of the respondents believed that they were unlikely to change their minds, **“Greater access to knowledge and expertise” and “Greater funding” were also the most significant reasons** (at 62% and 49% respectively) cited by the respondents for **potential reasons they might change their mind**.

3.2 General Takeaways

This section highlights the key reasons for the low uptake in youth entrepreneurship in Singapore. Firstly, youths have **low awareness of existing entrepreneurship programmes** and secondly, youths think it would be **useful to spark interest in entrepreneurship from young**.

3.2.1 Key takeaway 1: Youths have low awareness of existing entrepreneurship programmes

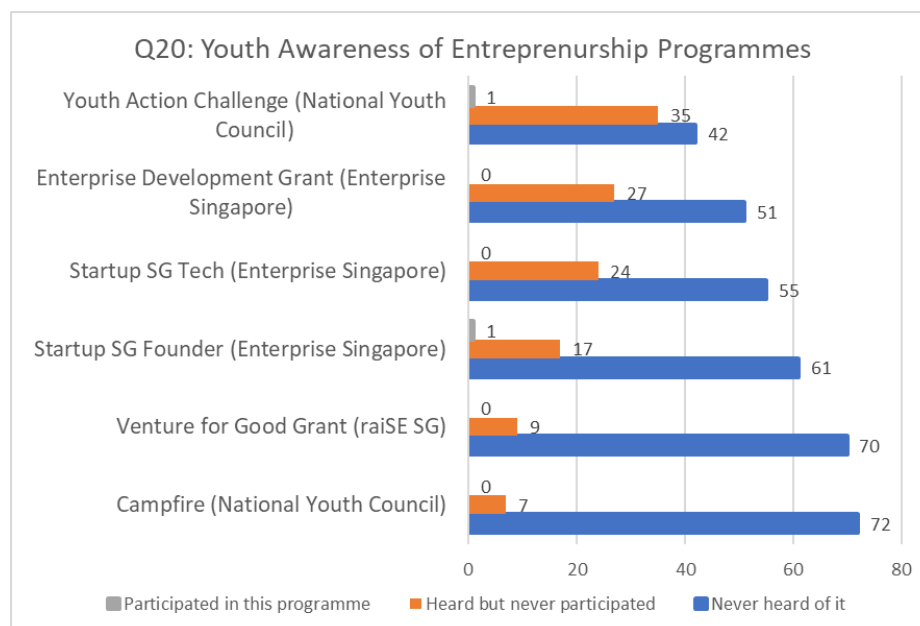


Figure 3.1: All responses to Q20: Youth Awareness of Entrepreneurship Programmes

Youths generally have little knowledge of existing entrepreneurship programmes. Lack of awareness ranged from 54% (for the Youth Action Challenge) to 91% (for Campfire). Even the

most popular programme (the Youth Action Challenge) only had one youth respondent who was a participant – but only as a volunteer. This suggests that youth entrepreneurship programmes may not have enough coverage amongst schools.

Table 3.1: All results from Q26: “What are some other ways you think the government can support entrepreneurship in Singapore?”

Reason	Number of responses (out of 79)	Percentage of responses (%)
Increase support and/or training for aspiring entrepreneurs	60	75.9%
Incorporate entrepreneurship modules into school curriculums to spark interest in entrepreneurship	57	72.2%
Make start-up funding easily accessible	55	69.6%
Improving public perception of entrepreneurship	44	55.7%
Others	5	6.3%

Furthermore, Q26 demonstrates that 69.6% of youth think that start-up funding needs to be made more accessible, despite the many grants available. Though the **highest response was to “increase support and/or training for aspiring entrepreneurs”**, it is possible that youths selected this because they were unaware of the current programmes available. Hence, **efforts should be focused on tackling this lack of awareness.**

3.2.2. Key takeaway 2: Youths think it would be useful to spark interest in entrepreneurship from young

Based on Q26 (Table 3.1), the **second highest response was to “incorporate entrepreneurship modules into school curriculums to spark interest in entrepreneurship”**. Based on our research of the current policy options in section 2.2, not many target the pre-tertiary level, which could result in a gap in knowledge and a lack of interest in entrepreneurship from a young age due to the lack of awareness.

3.3 Key takeaways from Respondents Interested in Entrepreneurship/Own a Business (Group A)

This section focuses on the 24 respondents who indicated that they intend to start a business or are currently running a business (henceforth referred to as group A). We assume these respondents have done more research into the entrepreneurship scene in Singapore, as they generally offered more specific feedback on the programmes.

They have two main characteristics: firstly, **Group A also has a low awareness of the various government schemes available to entrepreneurs**; secondly, they believe **building a community passionate about entrepreneurship is important**. There were further insights from the survey data that will not be discussed in our paper, but has been included in Appendix C.

3.3.1. Key takeaway 1: Group A has low awareness of the various government schemes available to entrepreneurs

Youths interested in entrepreneurship are more likely to have done research on the various schemes available. However, the lack of awareness in the multiple schemes we have highlighted indicates that some of these schemes may be difficult to find, thus, much more could be done to publicise these schemes. This is in line with 3.2.1.

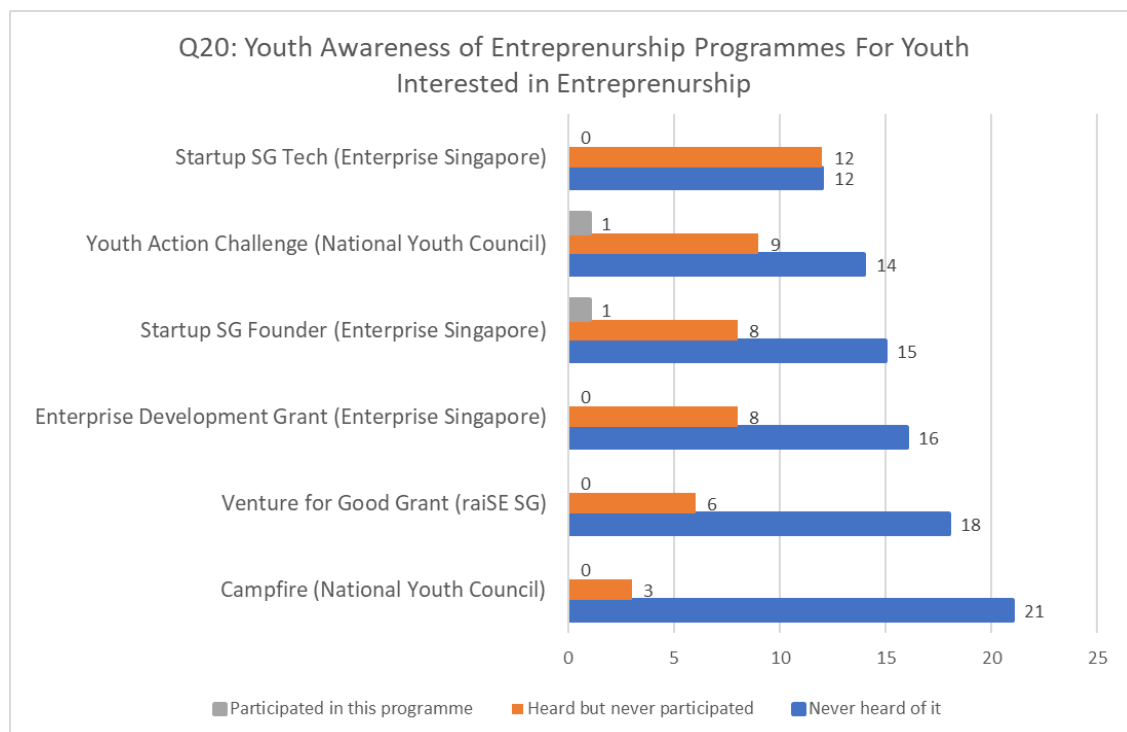


Figure 3.2: Responses of Group A to Q20: Youth Awareness of Entrepreneurship Programmes

Looking at the results of Q20 for those interested in entrepreneurship, we still see that most of them are unaware of entrepreneurship programmes in general.

Table 3.2: Responses of Group A to Q16: Discouragements Faced From Starting A Business

Reason	Number of responses (out of 17)	Percentage of respondents (%)
Insufficient knowledge and expertise	12	70.6%
Lack of capital/funds	11	64.7%
Fear of failure	7	41.2%
Insufficient interest	3	17.6%
Preference for structured employment	1	5.9%

When analysing Q16: “Discouragements faced from starting a business”, it can be seen that 52.9% of respondents put “Lack of capital/funds” and/or “Insufficient knowledge and expertise”, both which could be addressed by the myriad of programmes the government has available. Thus, **fostering greater awareness of the available entrepreneur programs could spur more interested youth to take the step to make their ideas a reality.**

3.3.2. Key takeaway 2: Group A believe building a community passionate about entrepreneurship is important

For Q26, **70.8% indicated that the government could “Incorporate entrepreneurship modules into school curriculums to spark interest in entrepreneurship”**. Furthermore, the lack of interest in the wider community could dampen the interests of those who are interested, as indicated by a respondent that he did not participate in any entrepreneurship programmes because he “Did not have a team of friends who were interested in entrepreneurship as well”, in response to Q22: “If you have not participated in any programme before, why?”

Comment 22.1

22.1	Did not have a team of friends who were interested in entrepreneurship as well
------	--

It suggests that the general culture of entrepreneurship is not strong in Singapore which corroborates with the other survey responses. The **difficulty in finding like-minded individuals to embark on a project could be another potential barrier that deters youths from pursuing entrepreneurship**, which highlights the importance of building a community interested in entrepreneurship.

The desire to network and form a stronger community is also indicated by Q23. 70.8% indicated that a successful youth entrepreneurship programme would include mentorship opportunities,

which would give them practical advice and also expand their network of like-minded individuals.

Table 3.3: Responses of Group A for Q23: “In your opinion, what components should a successful youth entrepreneurship programme include?”

Reason	Number of responses (out of 24)	Percentage of respondents (%)
A mentorship opportunity with successful entrepreneurs	17	70.8%
An incubation period to conceptualise and implement new ideas	14	58.3%
A guide on starting a business in Singapore	13	54.2%
A start-up fund to support new ventures	13	54.2%
A walkthrough of the entrepreneurship process	12	50%
A sharing on trends and new opportunities for entrepreneurs	12	50%
A feedback mechanism to seek third-party inputs	12	50%
Others	2	8.3%

3.4 Key takeaways from Respondents Uninterested in Entrepreneurship (Group B)

This section focuses on the key takeaways from the majority of the youths (55 out of 79), who are uninterested in entrepreneurship (henceforth referred to as Group B). Since their **disinterest mainly stems from insufficient knowledge, this mindset could potentially be changed with greater access to knowledge and expertise.**

3.4.1. Key takeaway 1: Group B’s disinterest mainly stems from insufficient knowledge

Table 3.4: Responses from youth uninterested in entrepreneurship for Q17: “Why do you not intend to start a business?”

Reason	Number of responses (out of	Percentage of respondents (%)
--------	--------------------------------	----------------------------------

55)		
Insufficient knowledge and expertise	36	65.5%
Insufficient interest	35	63.6%
Lack of capital/funds	29	52.7%
Preference for structured employment	29	52.7%
Fear of failure	19	34.5%

The majority of the youths surveyed are uninterested in entrepreneurship, of which “Insufficient knowledge and expertise” and “Insufficient interest” were the two key reasons, as seen from Q17.

3.4.2. Key takeaway 2: Group B’s disinterest in entrepreneurship could be changed with greater access to knowledge and expertise

Table 3.5: Responses from youth uninterested in entrepreneurship for Q19: “What might encourage you to start a business/freelancing?”

Reason	Number of responses (out of 55)	Percentage of respondents (%)
Greater access to knowledge and expertise	34	61.8%
Greater funding	27	49.1%
Greater access to mentors	20	36.4%
Nothing will encourage me	16	29.1%

In response to Q19, only 29.1% of respondents indicated that nothing will encourage them, while the other 71.9% are open to the idea. 61.8% of respondents indicated that **“Greater access to knowledge and expertise” could potentially change their minds regarding entrepreneurship**, making that a potential area to target.

4. PROPOSED INITIATIVES

We propose two initiatives as follows:

1. **Zonal Entrepreneurship Offices** which serve Group B (youths who lack interest in and/or knowledge of entrepreneurship) by organising programmes, workshops and talks to raise awareness about entrepreneurship and available opportunities should students be interested, and serve Group A by offering tailored advice to aspiring and current youth entrepreneurs.
2. A **Nationwide Entrepreneur Network** which serves Group A (youth interested in entrepreneurship/own a business) by aiming to reduce social capital inequality and create a stronger entrepreneurial community in Singapore.

4.1 Zonal Entrepreneurship Offices (ZEOs)

4.1.1 Overview of ZEOs

A ZEO can be established in each junior college (including Millennia Institute), to serve as a touchpoint for students within the college and to support outreach to a predetermined list of partner secondary schools that are located in the vicinity of the junior college. Since Polytechnics and IHLs already have entrepreneurship facilities, we focused on junior colleges for our recommendation. These offices can have dedicated staff and resources to develop programmes that help build an entrepreneurial culture among our youth.

General Introductory Programme for Group B

First, a general introductory programme targeted at all students from upper secondary to pre-tertiary institutions. Since this highly complements Education and Career Guidance (ECG) programmes, the latter can be redesigned to incorporate ZEO elements so that less additional curriculum time would be consumed. This could be achieved through compulsory talks, seminars and/or workshops that introduce students to what entrepreneurship is and dispel common myths surrounding entrepreneurship in Singapore. This is similar to how ECG programmes are currently being conducted in junior colleges, as part of the Character and Citizenship Education Syllabus.¹⁹ We could leverage off existing resources, such as the introductory courses of Ngee Ann Polytechnic's Minor in Entrepreneurship programme.²⁰ These programmes may be produced in collaboration with NYC to leverage NYC's experience in organising similar activities and NYC's status as an established organisation in the youth development scene to boost outreach and uptake of the entrepreneurship programmes. Programmes can also direct students to existing activities/resources (i.e. youth entrepreneurship programmes/grants above),

¹⁹ Ministry of Education, "Character and Citizenship Education Syllabus Pre-University", Ministry of Education Singapore, 2016, https://www.moe.gov.sg/-/media/files/programmes/character_and_citizenship_education_preu_syllabus.pdf.

²⁰ Ngee Ann Polytechnic, "Home," Home, 2022, <https://sites.google.com/np.edu.sg/entrepreneurship/pathway/home>.

given that the lack of awareness is a key reason for students not participating in such programmes (see 3.2.1). The introductory programme would also help to spark interest in students at a younger age when they have more time to explore entrepreneurship, another key obstacle to participation in entrepreneurship programmes (see 3.2.2), by highlighting safe spaces for students to learn through trial-and-error.

Tailored Guidance for Group A

Secondly, advice services that offer tailored guidance to students who are looking to start or have already started businesses. This parallels the provision of customised advice on future educational and occupational pathways by ECG counsellors, an existing programme under the Ministry of Education (MOE). ZEO counsellors would mainly provide advice for topics like potential sources of funding, networking opportunities, and business fundamentals. However, to note, ZEOs should aim to be the first touch-point to introduce youths to entrepreneurship and recommend relevant public and private programmes or forms of assistance, rather than providing specific consulting advice to grow their venture.

4.1.2 Flaws and Possible Mitigation

A concern might be the lack of framework or content available to newly established entrepreneurial offices. However, there is already a precedent of dedicated entrepreneurial offices for polytechnics and IHLs, as seen in Part 2.2.6. MOE can facilitate the sharing of ideas and resources between these offices to increase the accessibility of quality teaching material to students throughout Singapore's post-secondary education institutions.

Another concern is the significant resource expenditure required to establish and operate the ZEOs. For instance, junior colleges may not have the facilities available for a dedicated office to be set up. In addition, new staff would have to be engaged and trained to manage the ZEO, and this may incur significant costs for MOE. For the former, ZEOs may, at their initial phases, be located with the ECG offices of junior colleges, given that facility requirements are largely similar. If successful, ZEOs may subsequently be expanded to occupy personal offices within schools. For the latter, significant cost savings are expected given that ZEO staff will be serving a network of secondary schools partnered with the junior college, on top of the junior college itself.

To adequately address possible impediments to the functioning of ZEOs, our proposed ZEO pilot should be conducted within a junior college as a start. The junior college should preferably have appropriate physical amenities to host a ZEO, and in our proposal, MOE would directly allocate staff and conduct periodic review on the efficacy of the pilot. If successful, the ZEO scheme may then be rolled out islandwide.

4.1.3 Avenues for Expansion

To bolster student engagement, ZEOs may consider collaborating with the Entrepreneurship society of each school, if one exists, or recruiting students to become Entrepreneurship ambassadors. Currently, several junior colleges do have entrepreneurship societies, such as Nanyang Junior College's Biz Club, and Raffles Entrepreneurs' Network. Collaboration helps to augment the ZEOs capabilities to reach out to students, as students themselves can disseminate information on these services via word-of-mouth, and can organise ancillary activities to further promote usage of ZEOs services.

4.2 The Nationwide Entrepreneur Network (NEN)

4.2.1 Overview of the NEN

Unlike existing one-off programmes like the National Youth Council's Campfire programme, the NEN programme aims to create a sustained platform for current and aspiring entrepreneurs. It seeks to i) function as a portal to increase connectivity to existing entrepreneurship development programmes, ii) foster a stronger entrepreneurial community in Singapore, and iii) act as a space for youths to seek guidance and mentorship from more experienced entrepreneurs. We propose for the NEN to be set up through a collaboration between the National Youth Council and Enterprise Singapore. Additionally, we aim for this initiative to target the current lack of an entrepreneurial community amongst Singaporean youths, which was a reason cited as to why youths did not embark on entrepreneurship journeys.

Membership

Membership can be open to all residents of Singapore and Singaporeans abroad, but the proposed programmes would first focus on engaging youths and aspiring entrepreneurs. Upon registration, members can indicate their level of entrepreneurship experience, which would be reflected on their member profile. This allows aspiring entrepreneurs to identify and engage members with more experience, and vice versa for those who wish to mentor aspiring entrepreneurs. Youths can also join as members via the ZEOs, as our proposed initiatives can be closely linked.

Online Portal

The NEN programme can be managed in the form of an online portal. This allows for announcements to be made to the members, who can choose to attend events they have interest in. Such events could range from upcoming networking sessions with entrepreneurs and other youths interested in entrepreneurship, to established entrepreneurship programmes such as

NYC's Campfire and informal get-together or social events. Put together with activities organised by the ZEOs, this allows for interested youths to have consistent opportunities for development and collaboration.

Interaction Channels

The NEN can also establish a Discord or Slack channel for members to interact through. This gives aspiring youth entrepreneurs a platform to identify who might share similar interests and, hence, be potential collaborators for their endeavours. It provides them the opportunity to take initiative to make cold calls and form connections that might aid them on their entrepreneurship endeavour. It also paves the way for youths to form their own interest groups about technology, fashion, food and beverages, and other interests, in these extended channels. Through such means, individuals with similar interests from the same industries can form tighter-knit circles of mutual benefit where they can freely network and share useful information among themselves.

Networking Opportunities

Apart from promoting events organised by other organisations, the NEN programme could host networking events to aid aspiring entrepreneurs form meaningful and organic connections. For instance, successful entrepreneurs from a variety of fields can be invited to host speed networking sessions. There, they could share expertise and contacts with aspiring entrepreneurs who are interested in a similar field. Another example could be facilitating frequent entrepreneurship workshops. These can be conducted by entrepreneurship mentors or established entrepreneurs who wish to share about their experiences. Opportunities can be allocated within the programme to allow participants to interact with others in the community.

Collaboration Opportunities

The NEN can also facilitate collaboration among aspiring entrepreneurs. This can be done by establishing an annual programme to connect and support members who wish to pursue an entrepreneurial venture. Members can indicate their interest via a form and can be matched with members who are keen on similar pursuits. Separately, experienced entrepreneurs can indicate their interest in mentoring the teams formed. Once a team is formed, members can embark on their venture together. Teams are expected to work independently on their venture, but would have a mentor assigned to provide personalised guidance over a 6-month period. These mentors could be recruited from non-profit organisations like Advisory SG or other volunteer networks.

Fostering a Strong Entrepreneurial Community

The common platform creates a form of unity and togetherness for members of the entrepreneurial community, especially for the youths, who can embark on their entrepreneurship journey together with a supportive community. Not only are youths able to network with like-minded individuals, the portal can empower youths to promote their own business ventures. They could seek partners with converging interests to collaborate on projects, which is greatly

aided by the tightly-knit online community established by the NEN, allowing for personal and professional growth. Feedback, such as comment 22.1 from our survey, has shown that aspiring youth entrepreneurs might need support from peers to commit more into any business ideas that they wish to develop. Ultimately, while these opportunities should make it more accessible for youths to find a community of entrepreneurs and easier for youths to learn entrepreneurship skills through more accessible content, we would hope for the NEN programme to cater to an audience beyond existing youths. This would create an entrepreneurial community that not only attracts and supports youths, but also provides a more sustainable network of entrepreneurs in Singapore such that its impact can be longer lasting.

4.2.2 Flaws and Possible Mitigation

A potential concern might be the lack of incentive for youths to stay engaged in the long term, which could result in inactive membership. Since the membership is one of self-regulation, those who wish to be seen as active have to satisfy a minimum number of sessions for their 'Active' status to be maintained. Those who do not do so would be regarded as an 'Inactive' member. In addition, awards and titles can be awarded to top contributors e.g. providing greater incentives for members to be more active while being easy to administer.

4.2.3 Avenues for Expansion

The NEN has the potential to expand and collaborate with EDGE, due to the overlap in demographic and purpose, albeit with a larger scope than EDGE's current form. Apart from EDGE, collaborating with NPO-led initiatives such as NFTE can help to integrate students who are enrolled in different entrepreneurship programmes to seek partnerships with each other, and to perhaps learn more about their peers' experiences under a different model of developing entrepreneurial acumen.

5. CONCLUSION

The youth entrepreneurship landscape in Singapore is currently much less vibrant than those of our regional counterparts, as seen from how we ranked last among 6 countries in Southeast Asia, with only 17% of youths aspiring to be entrepreneurs in 2019.²¹ This puts us at risk of losing out in terms of innovation in the longer run. Moreover, the continued rolling out of youth entrepreneurship programmes, incubators and funds by the Singapore government and education institutes demonstrates that this is a priority in Singapore. Despite these efforts, youths interested/involved in entrepreneurship still lack knowledge and/or feel like they receive insufficient support (Group A), while most youths remain uninterested in and/or unaware of such efforts (Group B).

Our two-pronged proposal addresses these two key demographics. On the one hand, Zonal Entrepreneurship Offices (ZEOs) tackle Group B's lack of interest in and knowledge about entrepreneurship through educational programmes, while simultaneously offering Group A more customised advice to bridge gaps in their knowledge. On the other hand, the National Entrepreneurship Network (NEN) helps Group A meet other entrepreneurs to immerse them in a supportive community of like-minded youths, while reducing social capital inequality by aiding them in forming useful networks.

In sum, we believe that our paper provides valuable causal insights into low youth entrepreneurship rates and offers constructive suggestions, both of which complement current governmental efforts and can be expanded upon to better promote youth entrepreneurship.

²¹ Kimberly Lim, "Few Singaporean Youths Aim to Be Entrepreneurs, Most Have No Plans to Work Overseas: WEF Survey," TODAY, August 17, 2019, <https://www.todayonline.com/singapore/singapore-youths-come-last-survey-six-nations-entrepreneurial-ambition>.

APPENDIX

Appendix A - Survey Questions

SECTION 1: DEMOGRAPHIC QUESTIONS

1. Year Born
2. Race
3. Citizenship
4. Type of Institution
5. Option that Best Describes Respondent

SECTION 2: RUNNING A BUSINESS

6. Type of business
7. Whether business is formally registered in Singapore
8. Whether respondent intends to formally register business
9. Reasons for wanting to formally register business
10. Obstacles faced in formally registering business in Singapore
11. Reasons for not wanting to formally register business
12. Potential reasons for changing their minds (i.e. to grow and register their business)
13. Whether respondent would like to expand their business into other markets in Southeast Asia, and reasons for their choice

SECTION 3: INTENTION TO START A BUSINESS

14. What type of business respondent intends to run
15. Reasons for wanting to start a business
16. Discouragements faced from starting a business

SECTION 4: NO INTENTION TO START A BUSINESS

17. Reasons for not wanting to start a business
18. Elaboration on reasons from Q17.
19. Potential reasons for changing their minds (i.e. to start a business)

SECTION 5:

20. Tick the youth entrepreneurship programmes that you know of and/or have participated in or benefited from
21. If you have participated in any programme, please write down the year in the respective programmes in which you participated.
22. If you have not participated in any programme before, why? Please select all that apply, or select 'Not applicable' if you have attended a programme before

23. In your opinion, what components should a successful youth entrepreneurship programme include?
24. If you had participated in any programme, what did you find helpful and what do you think could be improved?
25. Besides entrepreneurship programmes initiated by the government, have you heard of and/or benefitted from other entrepreneurship programmes (e.g. in your school)? Please write 'Not applicable' if this does not apply to you. (long answer)
26. What are some other ways you think the government can support entrepreneurship in Singapore?

Appendix B - Survey Findings

The key survey information has been highlighted in the content above. However, other survey findings that shed light on potential areas for improvement have been included in this appendix.

SECTION 1: DEMOGRAPHIC QUESTIONS

1. Year Born

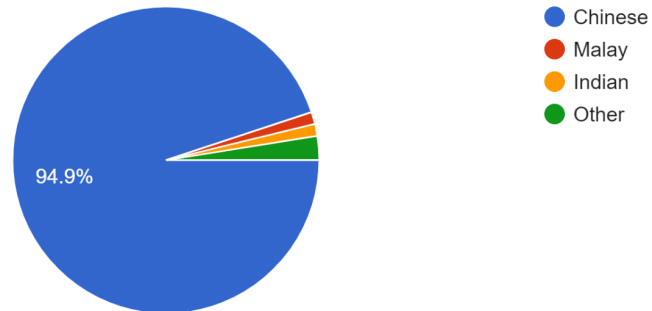
Birth Year	No. of Respondents
1996	1
1997	1
1998	5
1999	3
2000	3
2001	3
2002	43
2003	15
2004	1
2005	2

2. Race

Race	No. of Respondents
Chinese	75
Malay	1
Indian	1
Other	2

What is your race?

79 responses

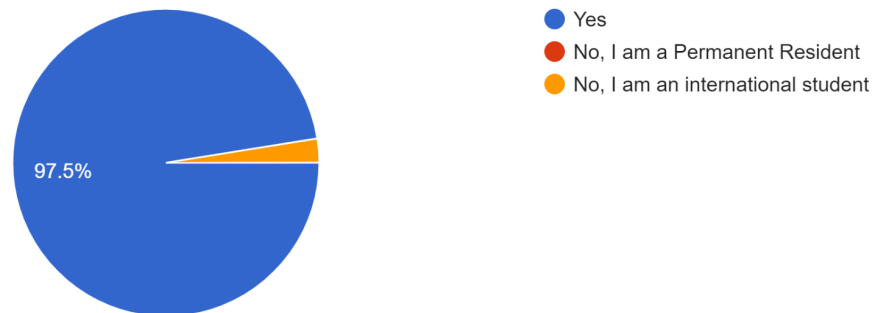


3. Citizenship

Citizenship	No. of Respondents
Singaporean Citizen	77
Permanent Resident	0
International Student	2

Are you a Singaporean citizen?

79 responses



4. Type of Institution

Type of Institution	No. of Respondents
Secondary School	44
Junior College	66
Polytechnic	2
Institute of Technical Education	0
Institutes of Higher Learning (e.g. NUS, NTU, NAFA, LASELLE)	16
National Service	27
Working Professional	2
Other	1

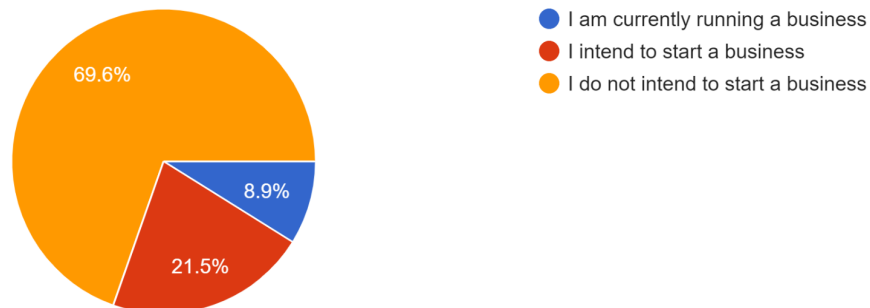
5. Option that Best Describes Respondent

Breakdown of who is running a business, wants to run one and has no interest

Option that Best Describes Respondent	No. of Respondents
I am currently running a business	7
I intend to start a business	17
I do not intend to start a business	55

Please select the option that best describes you

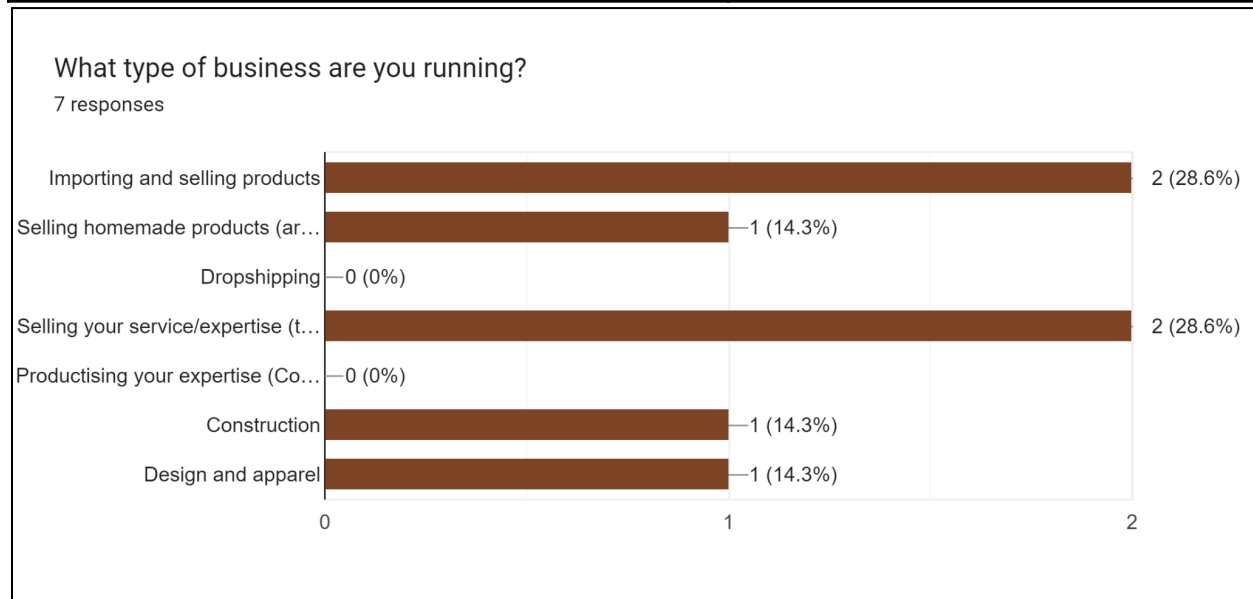
79 responses



SECTION 2: RUNNING A BUSINESS

6. Type of business

Type of business	No. of Respondents
Importing and selling products	2
Selling homemade products (art, food, jewellery, etc)	1
Dropshipping	0
Selling your service/expertise (tutoring, marketing, freelance writing, housecleaning, etc)	2
Productising your expertise (Courses, designs, ebooks, licensable assets, etc)	0
Other	2 (Construction; Design & Apparel)



7. Whether business is formally registered in Singapore

Whether business is formally registered in Singapore	No. of Respondents
Yes	4
No	3

8. Whether respondent intends to formally register business

Whether respondent intends to formally register business	No. of Respondents
Yes	1
No	2

9. Reasons for wanting to formally register business

Reasons for wanting to formally register business	No. of Respondents
I believe in the growth potential of my business	1
I want my business to grow further	1
Other	0

10. Obstacles faced in formally registering business in Singapore

Obstacles faced in formally registering business in Singapore	No. of Respondents
Knowledge and expertise about growing the business	0
Lack of capital/funds	0
Other	1 - “need a lawyer to work out the final details”

11. Reasons for not wanting to formally register business

Reasons for not wanting to formally register business	No. of Respondents
My business is a temporary arrangement	1
My business is not my main source of income	2
I want my business to remain small and flexible	2
I do not know how to grow my business	1
I do not have enough capital	1
Other	0

12. Potential reasons for changing their minds (i.e. to grow and register their business)

Potential reasons for changing their minds	No. of Respondents
Nothing will encourage me	1
Greater access to mentors	0
Greater access to knowledge and expertise	0
Greater funding	1

13. Whether respondent would like to expand their business into other markets in Southeast Asia, and reasons for their choice

Respondent #4: No, the market we are targeting is only for local market
Respondent #62: Ideally we would (as we are a partnership), but we want to be able to generate enough revenue on a domestic scale before branching out, as shipping overseas is more costly and we have to deal with more intermediaries along the way.
Respondent #72: No because I do not have the time
Respondent #73: Not for now. Focusing on domestic growth first
Respondent #74: Yes. To attract more customers.

SECTION 3: INTENTION TO START A BUSINESS

14. What type of business respondent intends to run

What type of business respondent intends to run	No. of Respondents
Importing and selling products	10
Selling homemade products (art, food, jewelry, etc)	1
Dropshipping	2
Selling your service/expertise (tutoring, marketing, freelance writing, housecleaning, etc)	10
Productising your expertise (Courses, designs, ebooks, licensable assets, etc)	4
Other	1 - "Pub"

15. Reasons for wanting to start a business

Reasons for wanting to start a business	No. of Respondents
I believe in the potential of my business idea	7
The possibility of making profits	10
Learning how to run a small business	9
Other	1 - "I have a dream to own a pub" (i.e. to simply fulfil a dream)

16. Discouragements faced from starting a business

Discouragements faced from starting a business	No. of Respondents
Insufficient interest	3
Insufficient knowledge and expertise	12
Lack of capital/funds	11
Fear of failure	7
Preference for structured employment	1

Other	0
-------	---

SECTION 4: NO INTENTION TO START A BUSINESS

17. Reasons for not wanting to start a business

Other comments

17.1	No good business ideas currently
17.2	I don't have an area that I feel very passionate about yet
17.3	singapore's climate rather difficult for starting a business
17.4	Got other things in mind to do
17.5	its something for a later stage of life when i have more knowledge, money, wisdom, ideas (everyth) to pursue it
17.6	I love the Singapore Armed Forces
17.7	No specific product/service I'm looking to offer

19. Potential reasons for changing their minds (i.e. to start a business)

Other comments

19.1	finding peers that have the same goals
19.2	a brilliant business idea
19.3	Time maybe I'll hate working for other people!
19.4	i feel business is a big commitment, so more time ig
19.5	Upon retirement

SECTION 5:

21. If you have participated in any programme, please write down the year in the respective programmes in which you participated.

21.1	2018-19 YAC but only as a volunteer not a full time member
21.2	Young Founders Singapore? something like that in 2020
21.3	SG Founder - 2020, NYC grants - 2019/2020, NTU Grants - 2019, NUS Enterprise Grants - 2020

22. If you have not participated in any programme before, why? Please select all that apply, or select 'Not applicable' if you have attended a programme before

19% of youths didn't participate in the programmes simply because they didn't know they existed rather than due to a lack of interest or time - with heightened awareness, there is potential for a greater interest in youth entrepreneurship.

Table: Results from the question: "If you have not participated in any programme before, why?"

Reason	Number of responses
I was not aware of any of these programmes/grants	48
I have no interest in embarking on a start-up	42
I cannot commit enough time to participate in the programme	36
The start-up funding offered by the programme is insufficient	1
The support and/or training offered by the programme is inadequate	4
I have attended similar programmes in the past	1
I do not require additional assistance to embark on a start-up	3
Not applicable	3
Others	4

Other comments

22.1	Did not have a team of friends who were interested in entrepreneurship as well
22.2	I'm not doing work that requires such programmes at the moment
22.3	haven't thought of an idea that I'm both passionate and confident about to compel me to join these programmes
22.4	In applicable grants, for example SG Tech requires a tech related startup, SG Founder requires Singaporean founders, raiSE requires it to be a social enterprise, so you need to find the right grants and not just "participate" all. Also the word "participate" is misleading. If you tried to get the grant but failed is that still considered a "participate"?

23. In your opinion, what components should a successful youth entrepreneurship programme include?

Table: All results from Q23

Reason	Number of responses
A guide on starting a business in Singapore	61
A mentorship opportunity with successful entrepreneurs	61
A start-up fund to support new ventures	56
A walkthrough of the entrepreneurship process	55
A sharing on trends and new opportunities for entrepreneurs	49
An incubation period to conceptualise and implement new ideas	45
A feedback mechanism to seek third-party inputs	46
Others	3

Other comments

23.1	Not only a venture fund, but a venture fund with a mentor and Entrepreneur-in-charge who sets bi-weekly KPIs. Needs an office space for the startup too as well as connections to UI/UX and Tech programmers who can help the startup.
23.2	More application based processes. You only really learn through trying and applying.

23.3	Networking opportunities for like-minded youth to exchange ideas and consolidate efforts across similar projects
------	--

24. If you had participated in any programme, what did you find helpful and what do you think could be improved?

Positive comments

24.1	I found that application processes tend to make people understand and learn more eg: being able to calculate finances, being able to ideate or draw instead of putting emphasis on the theoretical aspects.
24.2	advice on presentation and pitches useful

Critical comments

24.3	<i>I participated in a ton of programmes. What is helpful is always the feedback from different people with different mindsets. But what is not helpful is that the cost of labour in Singapore is way too high and the grants provided by the institutions are concentrated in past investments and they are not willing to invest more in new startups.</i> <i>1. Expand grant criteria. I understand that 90% of startups fail and the Government/IHL grants want to focus on the 10% that might succeed. But in doing so, they become overly selective in their criteria and may let many good startups slip past. They should try to provide more assistance to new startups with novel ideas, something that does not compete with the current startups funded by them.</i> <i>2. Cost of Labour is too high. If you are a techie founder and can do everything yourself, its fine. But if you are a business founder and need help in getting programmers, it is almost impossible. You can run through 5-6 NUS CS students and not get anything done by the end of the semester. If you want to get professional coders, be prepared to pay a ton of money. That is why some generous grants to at least help startups reach a PROOF-OF-CONCEPT or MINIMUM VIABLE PROTOTYPE is important. With that, we can test the suitability and sustainability of the business model and then evaluate whether more grants should be given, or grants and support to be withdrawn. With such high paying jobs outside, many tech students ask the question, why should I risk my time with a startup? I can easily earn \$6k taking on a back-end role, or \$7k full-stack role etc.</i> <i>3. Stop being unhelpful. What is not helpful is when the ""programme"" simply make you attend lots of ""ideation workshops"" to talk to people, and give you some ""mentorship sessions"" without actually providing any real resources to move the startup forward. Anyone, any business owner or business school professor, can come to these programmes and talk lots of stuff, but at the end of the day many of them offer nothing to your business."</i>
------	---

25. Besides entrepreneurship programmes initiated by the government, have you heard of and/or benefitted from other entrepreneurship programmes (e.g. in your school)? Please write ‘Not applicable’ if this does not apply to you. (long answer)

The answers that were not NA have been filtered out and presented in the table below.

25. 1	Yes. My ex-cofounders got the NTUitive \$10k grant which did get the startup going into an MVP. The startup worked and generated revenue but eventually it stopped because (a) unit economics does not make sense (making a loss if accounting for manhours), (b) insufficient funding to sustain the loss-making growth and (c) founding team breakup.
25. 2	I have heard of programmes for those who are interested in entrepreneurship such as NUS Overseas Colleges and NUS Entrepreneurship programmes and modules, as well as startup accelerators like Tribe Accelerator
25. 3	SUSS SBIZ Business Plan Competition
25. 4	Entrepreneurship clubs in university
25. 5	my JC (raffles) had an entrepreneurs club
25. 6	School modules

26. What are some other ways you think the government can support entrepreneurship in Singapore?

Table: results from Q26 for entrepreneurs: “What are some other ways you think the government can support entrepreneurship in Singapore”

Reason	Number of responses
Make start-up funding easily accessible	16
Increase support and/or training for aspiring entrepreneurs	16

Incorporate entrepreneurship modules into school curriculums to spark interest in entrepreneurship	17
Improving public perception of entrepreneurship	16
Others	2

Other comments

26.1	NOVEL entrepreneurship in Singapore is a terrible thing. When you come up with something new, everyone will say, nah, this hasnt been tested, and nobody wants to invest. IF you do something that has been done, like Grab or Gojek, people will say this has been done and you cannot compete with the big players. It is a lose-lose game. When you finally get people to believe in you and you start doing business, even when you start earning 10-20 thousand worth of revenue, people will say, this is still unprofitable, it is still loss-making, and it might take years to break even, and stop investing. That's the reality. It is a game for rich people, or people who can get rich friends to invest. Moreover, if you graduate from NUS, you probably have lots of good job opportunities out there. If you are smart enough to be a founder, you probably can land a job as a programmer in FAANG or become a business consultant in BCG/McKinsey/Bain and be paid much more than your pathetic startup. Literally, the entire environment in Singapore has to change to become more like that of the Silicon Valley in the U.S.
26.2	Increase support and/or training for aspiring entrepreneurs, I can name one thing I don't think would help — throwing money at the problem. The Singaporean economy is a quagmire of zombie SMEs that make middling revenue and survive intubated with government grant funding. The easy provision of funds to anyone and everyone who steps forward (even if they lack the commitment or ability to actually develop) results in an ecosystem in which grant funding becomes the ends and not a means of the core business model. The last thing I'd want is for a new generation of 'start-ups' to join the scene with a middling knowledge of how businesses are run, a product that only sounds good on paper, and a small team of employees bankrolled by the government to keep the lights on. I personally believe that entrepreneurship should only be undertaken by people who see a problem in society they want to fix, and not by MLM pawns hoping to become the next Elon Musk
26.3	Reduce ideologies that entering university and getting a degree is the only way to achieve success

26.4	Incorporate entrepreneurship modules into school curriculums to spark interest in entrepreneurship
26.5	Might be able to capitalise on existing programmes in school that already ask students to create something. I.e. extending it towards the business aspect

Appendix C - Other Unaddressed Issues Raised

For respondents who did not intend to formally register their business, the more common reasons cited included “My business is not my main source of income” and “I want my business to remain small and flexible”. Notably, while our respondent did not see a lack of knowledge and expertise nor a lack of capital as a significant obstacle, the respondent did highlight the **difficulty of getting a lawyer to work out details as an obstacle to formally register their business in Singapore**. Furthermore, while a respondent believed that nothing would change their minds and entice them to formally register their business, **receiving greater funding was cited as a potential motivator to formally register their start a business** change their minds.

Appendix D - Existing Initiatives to Support Entrepreneurship in Singapore

2.2.1 National Youth Council/ Campfire

The National Youth Council (NYC) serves as the national coordinating body for youth affairs in Singapore.²² In 2021, NYC launched the Campfire programme, a bi-annual six-week intensive programme specially designed for youths to promote entrepreneurship, design innovation, social enterprise, volunteerism and creative storytelling through pitching sessions with clients and Braintrust Advisors.²³

While these government-funded initiatives under NYC help equip Singapore’s future entrepreneurs with some expertise to tackle potential problems, the social entrepreneurship and sustainability focus of their programs may fall short in catering to youths who may wish to start businesses that do not necessarily seek to support a social cause, such as Love, Bonito and Awfully Chocolate.

2.2.2 Venture for Good

The Singapore Centre for Social Enterprise, raISE, was set up in 2015 through the joint effort of the Ministry of Social and Family Development, National Council of Social Service, Social

²² National Youth Council, “About Us,” NYC, 2023, <https://www.nyc.gov.sg/en/about-us>.

²³ Kim Shaw, “National Youth Council, *Scape and Tribal Worldwide Singapore Launch Campfire, a 6 Week Creative-Solutions Programme for Youths,” Campaign Brief Asia, April 2, 2021, <https://campaignbriefasia.com/2021/04/02/national-youth-council-scape-and-tribal-worldwide-singapore-launch-campfire-a-6-week-creative-solutions-programme-for-youths/>.

Enterprise Association and Tote Board, with the mandate to develop the social enterprise sector in Singapore. raiSE created the VentureForGood (VFG) grant to support social enterprises in various stages of their business, allowing new and existing social enterprises to apply for up to \$300,000 in grants.²⁴ However, given VFG's general aim of supporting social enterprises, youths who do not own established ventures or whose ventures still remain in its nascent stages are excluded.

2.2.3 Startup SG Tech

A grant supported by Enterprise Singapore, Startup SG Tech focuses on aiding Singaporean start-ups that provide groundbreaking innovations in proprietary technology. These grants, such as the Proof-of-Concept grant, and Proof-of-Value grant, are tiered according to the stage of development of the technology.²⁵

While the Startup SG Tech grant might be helpful to startups that focus on these technologies, the stringent requirements of its funding limits its accessibility since it caters to startups that have already conducted extensive development on their innovations, and have proven their commercial viability. Thus, it might not be the grant of choice for a large portion of youths that might have entrepreneurial ambitions, especially those who have yet to establish a startup.

2.2.4 Startup SG Founder

Launched by Enterprise Singapore in 2017, Startup SG Founder aims to nurture Singapore's start-up scene by providing mentorship and grants to entrepreneurs of varying experience levels.²⁶ It features two tracks- (1) 'Start' track targeted at entrepreneurs who already have a viable business plan and (2) 'Train' track targeted at aspiring entrepreneurs. With Singapore's 5 autonomous Universities as one of the Startup SG Founder's Accredited Mentor Partners (AMP), students are encouraged to apply. If deemed unique, startups can be granted continuation with AMP support.

Despite Startup SG Founder's comprehensive support in providing crucial funds and mentorship to experienced and aspiring entrepreneurs it still has its limitations. Not only does it require full-time commitment, which excludes those who are studying, it does not address broader societal issues such as the stigma towards failure, which contribute significantly to the low level of youth entrepreneurship in Singapore.

²⁴ Venture for Good, "What Is a Social Enterprise?," RaiSE, n.d., <https://www.raise.sg/ventureforgood.html>.

²⁵ Startup SG, "Startup SG - Startup SG Tech," Startup SG - The Singapore Startup Ecosystem, n.d., <https://www.startupsg.gov.sg/programmes/4897/startup-sg-tech>.

²⁶ Startup SG, "Startup SG - Startup SG Founder," Startup SG - The Singapore Startup Ecosystem, n.d., <https://www.startupsg.gov.sg/programmes/4894/startup-sg-founder>.

2.2.5 ACE and EDGE

The Action Community for Entrepreneurship (ACE) is the national voice for the Singapore startup ecosystem, and a key trade association representing the interests of startups in Singapore.²⁷ Working in close cooperation with the government and startups, ACE seeks to promote entrepreneurship, catalyse new growth opportunities, scale startups and build champion enterprises. ACE was established in 2003 by the Singapore Ministry of Trade and Industry, and re-launched as a private sector-led, non-profit organisation in 2014. Today, ACE has more than 2,000 members, representing over 1,300 startups.

EDGE is the youth wing of ACE.²⁸ EDGE connects young founders, student entrepreneurship clubs such as the NUS Entrepreneurship Society with industry partners, government, and ecosystem players to foster a more cohesive youth entrepreneurship scene in Singapore. EDGE organises webinars for guest speakers involved in the entrepreneurial community to share their experiences and expertise of specific fields with attendees, and provides educational material in the form of resource packs. EDGE focuses on the networking and educational aspects of supporting youth entrepreneurs and does not provide funding or grants.

2.2.6 Post-secondary Education Institutions (Polytechnics)

The five polytechnics in Singapore have their own youth entrepreneurship hubs, these are: Singapore Polytechnic's SPiNOFF Entrepreneurship Centre,²⁹ Nanyang Polytechnic's i0 Pre-incubator,³⁰ Republic Poly's Office of Entrepreneurship Development,³¹ Temasek Polytechnic's Entrepreneurship Centre,³² and Ngee Ann Polytechnic's Innovation and Entrepreneurship Office ("The Sandbox"). For this report, we chose to elaborate on Ngee Ann Polytechnic's programme as an example of the general programme and resources that polytechnics have.

Ngee Ann Polytechnic (NP)

Priding itself as the polytechnic for "budding innovators and entrepreneurs", Ngee Ann Polytechnic's Innovation and Entrepreneurship Office, the Sandbox, seeks to inspire entrepreneurial passion amongst its students and alumni community through a multitude of programmes, funding initiatives, innovation spaces, industry partnership opportunities, and

²⁷ ACE, "Ace – Action Community for Entrepreneurship," ACE Action Community for Entrepreneurship, 2023, <https://ace.org.sg/>.

²⁸ EDGE, "Home - Edge - Youth Entrepreneurship Singapore," EDGE, September 2, 2021, <https://edge.org.sg/>.

²⁹ Singapore Polytechnic, "SPiNOFF – Entrepreneurship Centre," SP. Accessed April 7, 2023. <https://www.sp.edu.sg/industry/spinoff>.

³⁰ Nanyang Polytechnic, "i0 Pre-Incubator," NYP. Accessed April 7, 2023.

<https://www.nyp.edu.sg/about-nyp/nyp-support-centre-and-services/i0-pre-incubator.html>.

³¹ Republic Polytechnic, "Office of Entrepreneurship Development," Accessed April 7, 2023. <https://www.rp.edu.sg/oed>.

³² Temasek Polytechnic. "Innovation & Entrepreneurship." Temasek Polytechnic. Accessed April 7, 2023. <https://www.tp.edu.sg/research-and-industry/innovation-and-entrepreneurship.html>.

mentorship programmes for aspiring entrepreneurs.³³

One key programme would be its Entrepreneurship First Steps course.³⁴ It is an online course targeted at Secondary School and NITEC students who want to know more about entrepreneurship, and who have aims of starting their own businesses in the future. Through the course, students would learn essential knowledge to start their own businesses, with a focus on discovering and developing valuable business ideas. In addition, NP also offers a Minor in Entrepreneurship, with 8 different Learning Units (LUs) for students to enrol in.³⁵ While the programmes that NP provides can be seen as enriching and beneficial, the extent of support still remains rather limited for more complex business ideas.

2.2.7 Institutes of Higher Learning (IHLs)

The National University of Singapore (NUS), Nanyang Technological University (NTU) and Singapore Management University (SMU) all have organisations that specifically support entrepreneurship. These organisations provide training, funding, resources and networking opportunities for those who wish to utilise them. While comprehensive, they are limited by the degree of support they can provide, particularly in terms of funding. They are also only eligible for those in the school community, predominantly students and staff. We will be using NUS Enterprise as an example, due to the relatively similar profiles of the entrepreneurship organisations of the tertiary institutions.

NUS Enterprise

NUS Enterprise seeks to actively advance innovation and entrepreneurship in NUS and beyond, offering opportunities for students to have an experiential entrepreneurial education, to have access to active industry partnerships and holistic entrepreneurship support. It hosts a variety of education programmes, such as the NUS Overseas College and the NUS Enterprise Summer Programme. More importantly, it offers extensive support to aspiring entrepreneurs, in initiatives such as the NUS Start-up Runway and the Philip Yeo Initiative.

Under the NUS Start-up Runway, NUS Enterprise offers Open Houses and career fairs for incubatee companies to hire students.³⁶ It also provides services such as accounting, secretarial and marketing communications for interested start-ups. It even provides grants for start-ups that wish to explore overseas markets, and offer partners for greater access to new markets.

³³ Ngee Ann Polytechnic, “The Sandbox - Innovation & Entrepreneurship (I&E) Office,” Ngee Ann Polytechnic (NP), 2022, <https://www.np.edu.sg/student-life/the-sandbox-innovation-entrepreneurship>.

³⁴ Ngee Ann Polytechnic, “Ngee Ann Polytechnic,” Entrepreneurship First Steps, 2023, <https://np-efs.thinkific.com/courses/entrepreneurship-first-steps>.

³⁵ Ngee Ann Polytechnic, “Home,” Home, 2022, <https://sites.google.com/np.edu.sg/entrepreneurship/pathway/home>.

³⁶ National University of Singapore, “NUS Start-up Runway,” Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2023, <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/supporting-entrepreneurs/nus-start-up-runway/>.

As for the Philip Yeo Innovation Fellows Programme, it allows awardees to receive up to \$20,000 in funding, mentorship and network opportunities.³⁷ Awardees are to have demonstrated passion and unconventional thinking, with ideas to benefit society through entrepreneurial endeavours

There are also facilities available for entrepreneurs who wish to tap into NUS' resources. For instance, The Hangar, a workspace catered specifically for entrepreneurs, would be beneficial for start-ups at the early stage of development.³⁸

2.2.8 Non-Profit Organisations Collaborating with Secondary Schools

Several Secondary Schools and Primary Schools have engaged non-profit organisations to carry out entrepreneurship programmes, with the intention to develop students' innovative skills at a young age. While these programmes may be helpful, they only benefit a small group of schools in Singapore. Often it is the decision of the school management to engage these organisations. Furthermore, there can be different approaches towards developing entrepreneurial skills, since different vendors are utilised for these programmes. Hence, there are still remaining gaps when it comes to developing an entrepreneurial mindset amongst students.

One such organisation is the Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship by the Halogen Foundation, which targets youths from underserved communities, with the aim to develop an entrepreneurial mindset, as well as pick up business skills.³⁹ It engages Secondary Schools in Singapore, offering a multitude of programmes that include curriculum coaching, business visits as well as forming business pitches. It has partnered with some Secondary Schools including Anderson Secondary School and Serangoon Garden Secondary School.

³⁷ National University of Singapore, "Philip Yeo Innovation Fellows Programme," Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2020, <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/funding/philip-yeo-innovation-fellows-programme/>.

³⁸ National University of Singapore, "The Hangar," Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2023, <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/supporting-entrepreneurs/nus-startup-runway/the-hangar/>.

³⁹ Halogen Foundation Singapore, "Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship," Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship, 2023, <https://halogen.sg/programmes/nfte/>.

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- ACE. “Ace Position Paper.” ACE Action Community for Entrepreneurship, January 2022. <https://ace.org.sg/ace-position-paper/>.
- ACE. “Ace – Action Community for Entrepreneurship.” ACE Action Community for Entrepreneurship, 2023. <https://ace.org.sg/>.
- EDGE. “Home - Edge - Youth Entrepreneurship Singapore.” EDGE, September 2, 2021. <https://edge.org.sg/>.
- Halogen Foundation Singapore. “Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship.” Network for Teaching Entrepreneurship, 2023. <https://halogen.sg/programmes/nfte/>.
- Heng, Swee Keat. “DPM Heng Swee Keat at the Singapore Apex Business Summit.” Prime Minister's Office Singapore, March 22, 2022. <https://www.pmo.gov.sg/Newsroom/DPM-Heng-Swee-Keat-at-the-Singapore-APEX-Business-Summit>.
- Kritikos, Alexander S. “Entrepreneurs and Their Impact on Jobs and Economic Growth.” IZA World of Labor, May 1, 2014. <https://wol.iza.org/articles/entrepreneurs-and-their-impact-on-jobs-and-economic-growth/long>.
- Lim, Kimberly. “Few Singaporean Youths Aim to Be Entrepreneurs, Most Have No Plans to Work Overseas: WEF Survey.” TODAY, August 17, 2019. <https://www.todayonline.com/singapore/singapore-youths-come-last-survey-six-nations-entrepreneurial-ambition>.
- Ministry of Education, “Character and Citizenship Education Syllabus Pre-University”, Ministry of Education Singapore, 2016, https://www.moe.gov.sg/-/media/files/programmes/character_and_citizenship_education_preu_syllabus.pdf.
- Nanyang Technological University. “NTU Entrepreneurship Start-up Training.” NTUitive, 2023. <https://www.ntuitive.sg/whats-going-on/our-events/upcoming/NEST-Programme>.
- Nanyang Technological University. “The Innovation & Enterprise Company of Nanyang Technological University.” NTUitive, 2023. <https://www.ntuitive.sg/>.

- National Research Foundation. “Rie2025 Plan.” National Research Foundation, 2021. <https://www.nrf.gov.sg/rie2025-plan>.
- National University of Singapore. “NUS Enterprise.” Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2023. <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/about-us/our-purpose/>.
- National University of Singapore. “NUS Start-up Runway.” Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2023. <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/supporting-entrepreneurs/nus-start-up-runway/>.
- National University of Singapore. “Philip Yeo Innovation Fellows Programme.” Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2020. <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/funding/philip-yeo-innovation-fellows-programme/>.
- National University of Singapore. “The Hangar.” Enterprise.nus.edu.sg, 2023. <https://enterprise.nus.edu.sg/supporting-entrepreneurs/nus-startup-runway/the-hangar/>.
- National Youth Council. “About Us.” NYC, 2023. <https://www.nyc.gov.sg/en/about-us>.
- Ngee Ann Polytechnic. Home, 2022. <https://sites.google.com/np.edu.sg/entreneurshippathway/home>.
- Ngee Ann Polytechnic. “Ngee Ann Polytechnic.” Entrepreneurship First Steps, 2023. <https://np-efs.thinkific.com/courses/entrepreneurship-first-steps>.
- Ngee Ann Polytechnic. “The Sandbox - Innovation & Entrepreneurship (I&E) Office .” Ngee Ann Polytechnic (NP), 2022. <https://www.np.edu.sg/student-life/the-sandbox-innovation-entrepreneurship>.
- Phua, Rachel. “Shopee's Parent Company Sea Commits to Hiring 500 Singaporeans in Tie-up with Imda.” CNA, October 2, 2020. <https://www.channelnewsasia.com/singapore/shopee-sea-imda-commits-to-hiring-500-singaporeans-730291>.
- Quek, Christopher. “The Shame Faced by Singapore Startup Founders Who Fail Is Real. Here's What We Can Do.” TODAY, September 18, 2019. <https://www.todayonline.com/commentary/shame-faced-singapore-startup-founders-who-fail-real-heres-what-we-can-do>.
- Rutan, Ryan. “Series A, B, C, D, and E Funding: How It Works.” Series A, B, C, D, and E Funding: How It Works | Startups.com, April 26, 2022. <https://www.startups.com/library/expert-advice/series-funding-a-b-c-d-e>.

- Sern, Oon Tian. "Commentary: The Future Just Got Brighter for Aspiring Singapore Tech Entrepreneurs." CNA, February 17, 2020. <https://www.channelnewsasia.com/commentary/singapore-tech-entrepreneurs-start-up-grants-youth-challenge-774631>.
- Shaw, Kim. "National Youth Council, *Scape and Tribal Worldwide Singapore Launch Campfire, a 6 Week Creative-Solutions Programme for Youths." Campaign Brief Asia, April 2, 2021. <https://campaignbriefasia.com/2021/04/02/national-youth-council-scape-and-tribal-worldwide-singapore-launch-campfire-a-6-week-creative-solutions-programme-for-youths/>.
- Singapore Management University. "Incubator." Institute of Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 2023. <https://iie.smu.edu.sg/incubator>.
- Singapore Management University. Institute of Innovation & Entrepreneurship, 2023. <https://iie.smu.edu.sg/>.
- Spirit of Enterprise. "Student Entrepreneur Programme." Student Entrepreneur Programme, 2023. <https://soe.org.sg/student-entrepreneur-programme/>.
- Startup SG. "Startup SG - the Singapore Startup Ecosystem." Startup SG - The Singapore Startup Ecosystem, 2022. <https://www.startupsg.gov.sg/programmes>.
- Startup SG. "Startup SG - Startup SG Founder." Startup SG - The Singapore Startup Ecosystem, n.d.. <https://www.startupsg.gov.sg/programmes/4894/startup-sg-founder>.
- Startup SG. "Startup SG - Startup SG Tech." Startup SG - The Singapore Startup Ecosystem, n.d.. <https://www.startupsg.gov.sg/programmes/4897/startup-sg-tech>.
- Venture for Good. "What Is a Social Enterprise?" RaiSE, n.d.. <https://www.raise.sg/ventureforgood.html>.
- Wang, Jue. "Innovation and Government Intervention: A Comparison of Singapore and Hong Kong." *Research Policy* 47, no. 2 (2018): 399–412. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.respol.2017.12.008>.
- WIPO. "Global Innovation Index 2022 – Which Are the Most Innovative Countries." RSS News, 2022. https://www.wipo.int/global_innovation_index/en/2022/.